NEWS ON AIR: SPOTLIGHT

A Discussion on the Prime Minister's Visit to Tamil Nadu and Launch of Development Projects

Chapter 1: Program introduction

This is Akashwani. In the program spotlight, now we bring you a discussion on Prime Minister's visit to Tamil Nadu and launch of development projects. The participants are Shakhar Ayar, political analyst and Sarabjit Kore, anchor. **Anchor:** Hello listeners, welcome to Spotlight. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Chennai has brought into focus a series of major development **initiatives** worth over 13,000 cr rupees covering infrastructure, connectivity, education and scientific research. The visit featured projects spanning metro rail, national highways, railway stations, ports and petroleum with a **significant** focus on strengthening Tamil Nadu's transport infrastructure and economic **potential**. The dedication of the Sudha Gopalakrishnan Brain Center at IIT Madras also highlighted the importance of scientific research and **innovation**. What are the key takeaways from the Prime Minister's visit? How could these **initiatives** contribute to Tamil Nadu's development and improve the lives of its people? To explore these questions and understand the broader **implications** of the visit, we are joined by our expert Mr. Shakhar Ayar, political analyst. Mr. Shakhar Ayar, welcome to the program.

Chapter 2: Collaborative federalism

Mr. Ayar: Thank you very much. I think the most important thing to remember about this visit is this is the first visit of the prime minister to Tamil Nadu after the installation of a new government in the state headed by Chief Minister Vijay. The last 5 years it was headed by MK Stalin of the DMK. We have seen during that period what was the nature of relationship between Tamil Nadu government and the center due to political reasons. But today the most **significant** thing is after a long gap what we saw was Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Vijay traveling to the airport to receive him, joining him through all the projects that were inaugurated, sending a signal that the center and the state government are going to work together. This is a very, very big important message coming from Tamil Nadu and prime minister made it very clear that the center is going to work with the new Tamil Nadu chief minister for the development of the southern state. And what is important to note today was prime minister recalled his own experience particularly in the area of development and the challenges that a chief minister faces.

He recalled that governments may come and go because he has himself worked with so many chief ministers... but one thing is clear that his own commitment to Tamil Nadu and his own commitment to the people of Tamil Nadu has remained steadfast. We are taking this journey forward with the new chief minister.

Chapter 3: Development and metro rail

Anchor: So Mr. Ayar, taking the discussion further from the point of **collaborative** federalism and this message of collaboration, this message of public good. So these 13,000 cr rupees development projects they are spread out across a wide **spectrum** of areas. It could be transport, highways, railways, ports. Now how would you assess the overall significance of these **initiatives** for Tamil Nadu?

Mr. Ayar: You see as you mentioned this covers metro rail, it covers highways, it covers ports, it covers petroleum projects and as well as the educational sector also. Now the whole idea is as the prime minister mentioned today, the **initiatives** are going to improve daily **commuting** in urban centers. They are going to strengthen industrial and trade activities and most importantly they are going to generate employment. So interestingly today there were some projects that are completed projects and there are some for which foundation stone has been laid. So some will make daily travel easier. Some will strengthen industry and trade. But the whole idea is that all these developmental activities will actually create more jobs for young people across Tamil Nadu. That is very important. For instance, Prime Minister talked about how Metro Rail services were initially in 2014 when he took office, present only in five cities. Today it has spread to 25 cities.

Chapter 4: Transportation infrastructure

Anchor: So this indeed is a very interesting facet Mr. Ayar and you just spoke about making daily **commuting** easier and this of course touches the lives of the common man in a great way. So with special reference to the inauguration of the Poonamallee-Vadapalani stretch of phase 2 of the Chennai Metro Rail project... What do you have to say about this project in specific?

Mr. Ayar: This area is a highly dense, population-thick area. The services through this are going to be very important. And the inauguration of the 36 km four-lane section of this NH-744 is going to improve connectivity to **pilgrimage** centers, industrial, and commercial centers and will help in smoother movement of people and goods.

Tamil Nadu is a highly urbanized state with a strong rural economy. So when you have these kinds of projects, this is going to be very **significant** because it is going to not only boost the economy but also improve the trade from the hinterland to the coastal areas, to the ports, to rail heads. The prime minister also inaugurated a four-lane Madurai ring road section. Madurai we know is one of the oldest cities of India and by having this ring road around the Madurai city, which is a temple city, this is going to ease **congestion** from inside the city.

Chapter 5: Economic connectivity

Anchor: So since we're talking about smoother movement of goods and people, how do national highway projects... strengthen connectivity between cities, industrial centers, smaller towns while also supporting economic growth?

Mr. Ayar: If you go back in history and if you recall how the United States of America developed, it all began with connectivity when highways were built across from west coast to east coast... that attracted **entrepreneurs** to set up factories and once factories were set up, products had to be shipped to different centers. So without connectivity in the first place, you cannot attract **entrepreneurs**, you cannot attract investment. Similarly here what we are seeing in India is the first of these highway expansions occurred during Atal Bihari Vajpayee's first NDA government... Today if you go to the market and if you are buying tomatoes they come from Karnataka, Maharashtra, different parts. Some of them are a **perishable** commodity and they have to be transported fast. This has really helped our farmers, similarly small traders, medium industries, even their products need to reach the nearest marketing centers.

Chapter 6: Maritime development

Anchor: Mr. Ayar, since we are reiterating the importance of connectivity, I would like to talk also about the projects at Chennai port, Kamarajar port and V.O. Chidambaranar port. How do these underline the importance of maritime infrastructure and... improve **logistics** **efficacy**, facilitate trade and strengthen Tamil Nadu's position as an important industrial and commercial hub?

Mr. Ayar: Yes, there are at least three projects here which are very important. They are basically to improve and increase the cargo handling capacity of these ports. And the other thing that is very important is that not only cargo handling but also **logistics** connectivity. All ports need good rail connectivity and they must also have close airport connectivity... This government is giving a lot of emphasis on a holistic development of infrastructure and that is why there has been massive expansion. Overall shipping sector is being given a lot of investment.

Chapter 7: Railway modernization

Anchor: You just touched upon rail connectivity. Five railway stations... were included in the Amrit Bharat station initiative. What does the **modernization** of railway stations mean for passenger **amenities** and regional development?

Mr. Ayar: Today we saw railway infrastructure worth over 750 cr being dedicated... He also dedicated three rail flyovers in Coimbatore and surrounding areas which will ease **congestion** at busy level crossings, reduce waiting time and improve road safety. And the five Amrit stations... these are all being developed under the Amrit Bharat station scheme. So this is very **significant**. In the last few years, you have seen a number of improvements have been made to the kind of coaches that have been deployed across the country. Old coaches have been replaced with new modern safer coaches, and particularly coaches that can withstand collision impact.

Chapter 8: Scientific innovation

Anchor: Mr. Ayar, another important highlight of the prime minister's visit to Tamil Nadu was the dedication of the Sudha Gopalakrishnan Brain Center at IIT Madras. How can such advanced research facilities contribute to our understanding of the human brain and strengthen India's position in cutting-edge scientific research?

Mr. Ayar: This particular project is actually part of IIT Madras and in fact, it's one of the **frontier** areas of research where the intention is to map more than 100 human brains and they are being mapped for the purpose of three-dimensional atlases at a cellular resolution level... The prime minister also released a project to study the stroke atlas basically, and this features more than 1,000 **annotated** microscopic sections of the stroke-affected brain. So this atlas will strengthen researchers worldwide and identify what kind of **therapeutic** targets will have to be evolved and met. It's a very interesting area.

Chapter 9: Conclusion and wrap-up

Anchor: Listeners, as we conclude today's discussion, the prime minister's visit to Chennai has highlighted several important **dimensions** of development from modern transport infrastructure and improved connectivity to port development, education and scientific research. As Tamil Nadu continues to play an important role in India's industrial, educational and technological landscape, these projects underline the importance of **sustained** investment in infrastructure and human development. Mr. Shakhar Ayar, thank you very much for sparing your valuable time and sharing such **insightful** thoughts with us.